The Road Out

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/35087668.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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Character:
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Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Angst, Angst with a Happy Ending, Hurt/Comfort, Polyamory, Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Alcohol Withdrawal

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by DeltaFell

Summary

When Adora disappeared, Catra turned to drinking, and as the years wore on, remained sober less and less of the time. Except for the day she found out that Adora had gone missing. Every year, she didn't have a single drink. For Finn, if not for herself.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Catra stared at the bottle in her hand. Was not drinking it even worth all the pain anymore? How could she really believe that her memories would ever be enough?

From behind her, Catra heard a little voice.

"Mama, what's this?" Finn asked.

Catra immediately hid the bottle, but they couldn't be talking about the bottle. They had said this,' as if they had found some strange bug and wanted to see if she knew what it was. Catra spun around to look at Finn.

"What is it, kit? It better not be some nasty bug again." Catra laughed.

It wasn't a bug. Finn was holding up an old faded photograph of Catra standing next to a tall, buff, blonde woman. They were standing under an old oak tree together, Catra in the photo looked much younger than she was now.

"Where did you find this?" Catra said.

"One of the photos by the bathroom fell down and this came out behind it. And it has Catra + Adora forever written on the back. What does that mean, mama? Who' s Adora? Is she the woman with you in the photo?" said Finn.

Catra bit back a sob. How could she stand to tell them, knowing what telling them would do to them.

She began to just tell Finn that Adora was just someone who she used to know - an old friend she had fallen out of contact with, but then she remembered their promise to the then-unborn Finn. They had promised they wouldnt lie to them, her and Adora both. Adora would want Finn to know.

"Finn, sweetie, Adora is the woman with me in that photo, yes. She' s your other mother," Catra said.

"Where is she?" asked Finn.

"She' s gone, kit. One day she just never came back from a job."

Finn stepped forward and wrapped their arms around her. "It' s okay Mama, Im here and Im not going anywhere."

Catra did her best not to sob into Finn's shoulder as they hugged her.

The next day Catra woke up with a splitting headache. She laid in bed for at least a solid twenty minutes before she crawled out of bed to grab a whiskey and a coffee.

Catra stood there, stirring her drink thoroughly before slugging as much of it back in one go as she could.

Her headache was still going pretty strong after the alcohol kicked in, so she texted Scorpia she wasn't going to make it in today. It was noon already, and Scorpia probably knew anyway, but Catra was not going to leave her wondering. Not after Adora.

'The anniversary?' she texted back.

'Last night. Still feel like shit,' Catra responded. The light of her phone just made the headache even worse.

'Okay. Let us know if Finn needs to stay with their Auntie Scorpia and Auntie Perfuma,' Scorpia said.

Catra's phone buzzed with a notification. She dismissed it without even reading it. Everybody worth bothering knew to leave her alone today.

Catra curled up in a blanket on the single sofa she owned, and sat down to watch what had been Adora's favorite show. As sad as the memory was, it always managed to cheer her up some around the anniversary.

If she kept the brightness and sound on the TV low, Catra could tolerate the assault of noise and light on her pain-stricken head. Catra gulped down the last of her beer and tried to stand up to grab more, but she stood up too quickly and her vision tunneled rapidly. Catra fell to one knee, trying to regain some vision, but the small pinprick left vanished, and the last thing Catra felt was a dizzying sensation followed by a sharp rap to the back of her head.

The next thing Catra knew someone or something was poking her repeatedly.

"Ow, cut it out," Catra tried to say. She wasn't certain, but she thought it sounded more incoherent than that.

Whoever it was kept poking at her, and eventually Catra opened her eyes. She was on the floor - in the living room maybe, it was hard to focus her eyes. Before she got the chance to berate whatever motherfucker thought it was a good idea to interrupt her perfectly

good nap to deal with being hungover, she saw Finn looking down at her.

"Are you okay Mommy?" they said.

Catra lifted her head some, blinked and took in her surroundings.

"How'd you get in, kit?" Catra asked.

"Auncle Dee let me in. They picked me up from school and got me some ice cream. Then we came back here. Are you okay?" Finn said.

Catra leaned up off the floor some, "I'm fine, kit, although it might be a good day for a slumber party with Auntie Perfuma and Auntie Scorpia. Auncle Dee and I need to have a private conversation."

Catra stood up, groaning, as Finn ran down the hall to Perfuma and Scorpia's apartment. As soon as they were inside their apartment, Catra whirled on Double Trouble.

"What the fuck are you thinking going anywhere near my child! I don't want a fucking gang dealer anywhere near Finn! Who fucking let you pick Finn up from school?"

“Oh, and you think you're any better , kitten? Y ou did and dealt just as many drugs as Idid back then, until Adora pulled you out. Ididnt have anyone who cared enough to even extend a fucking hand! And these days I'm cleaner than you are. Y ou're the one who introduced me to Finn yourself, but you are so drunk these days you cant even remember that! So dont try to pull any sanctimonious bullshit on me.” Double T rouble took a breath and steadied themself.

“When you stopped responding to Scorpia’ s texts, she called me, since my classes today ended early enough that Icould pick them up and keep them entertained until Scorpia and Perfuma could have them over, because my apartment is no place for a magicat kitten, not yet anyways.”

Double Trouble’s tongue lashing left Catra stunned. She didnt know how to react. They leaned on her kitchen counter, brushing away some of the layer of detritus that coated the kitchen.

“And ultimately? What really gets my goat, is that you do all this with Finn counting on you to back them up. Do what you want on your own time, but they need you, and you've abandoned them in favor of the bottle. You used to try and stay sober for them on the anniversary even though they didnt know - seriously kitten, that’ s a little messed up - but judging by how you were on the floor today , you must have abandoned that too.”

Catra leaned against a wall, slid down, and sobbed. “I’ s true, Ive been a terrible parent to Finn, Ijust cant stop, being drunk just

makes it easier to deal with the pain of Adora being - “Catra hiccuped - “being gone.”

“Hey , hey now, I- fuck how do the guidance counselors do this, I have no clue what to do. Five years in the theater department and I still don’t know how to deal with someone having a breakdown. Um, fuck, uh, don’t cry , kitten, it’s not the end of the world.”

Catra sniffled, “It’ s not?”

“No, look, just because you’ve been fucking up severely for the last few years doesn’t mean that you can’t do better in the future. W e get you into rehab again, and find someplace for Finn to stay while you’re in, and I’ll keep an eye on you to keep you from relapsing.”

“Why? Why are you doing this for me?”

“I’m not just doing it for you, kitten, Adora was always a good little girl. She would hate to see what’s become of you. B t ultimately I’m doing this for Finn. They deserve better than what they’ve gotten,” Double Trouble said.

Catra gingerly stepped down the staircase into her living room. The hangover headache of yesterday had become a full on migraine

today.

She pulled out her phone, sighing, as she poured out a bowl of cereal for herself. She should probably get this over with, she knew.

'Hey, Perfuma, can I ask something of you and Scorpia? I'll explain why, I just don't want Scorpia to be ashamed of me. For some reason I get the feeling you'll understand.'

'Of course, Catra. I will always respect your privacy. What can we do for you?'

Catra fidgeted. She had to at least tell Perfuma, while Scorpia wouldn't need a reason, someone should at least know. She hated this self-improvement shit.

'Well, I'm getting myself into rehab, and I need someone to look after Finn while I'm in. They already think of you two as family.'

'I'm glad you're choosing to improve your self-care. We would love to host Finn while you go for rehab. How long will you be gone?' Perfuma said.

'I'm doing a three week program, but I only expect to be gone for a few days,' Catra replied.

'And just between us, Ithink Scorpia would be so proud that you're acknowledging and working on your issues,'said Perfuma.

Catra glared ineffectually at her phone between bites.

Just as she was finishing her cereal, there came a knock on her door. t had to be Double T rouble, coming to pick her up and take her to the rehab center. Did they really have to come so fucking early, it was eight A.M. for fucks sake.

Catra opened her door, "DT , did you have to come so fucking early"?

"Ooh, saucy of you, kitten, but we won't be getting there today ,"said Double Trouble.

"Y ou know what Imeant you horny fucking lizard,"Catra said.

Double Trouble merely smirked.

Catra climbed into their car, astonished at the flamboyant shade of green they had managed to acqire a reasonable Outback in. Somehow, even the upholstery was bright fucking green.

As if they knew exactly what she was thinking, Double T rouble spoke up, "I have my ways, kitten, I have my ways."

Catra was anxious the entire ride to the rehab clinic. She kept tapping her fingers against her leg, beating to a rhythm that nobody else could hear. Catra knew this would be good for her, good for Finn, but that did nothing to assuage the dread building in her chest.

In a moment of weakness, Catra turned to Double T rouble. "DT , do you think that any of this could even work? Even after Adora pulled me out, I damn near fell all the way back down, again. Should I just rip the band-aid off now for Finn and give them over to Scorpia and Perfuma?"

Once again, Double Trouble seemed caught off guard by Catra's display of her raw emotions. They met her eyes in the rearview mirror. "Look, Kitten, you can't just give up on yourself because I, however rightfully, chewed you out for failing Finn. You really were doing better there for a while, you can't be blamed for Adora' s death. Some things that affect you are out of your control. All you can do is try to better yourself, and pick yourself up after you fall."

Catra sniffled a little bit, "Speaking from personal experience?"

Double Trouble scoffed, "Hardly , Kitten, such a radiant being such as myself is innately without flaw, and I have done no wrong, ever . No matter what the courts say."

"Just fucking shoot me before I have to contend with your ego for room in the car," said Catra.

"I could never do that to my darling Finn, they would be so hurt. Anywho kitten, we're here now, so go on and scoot inside, I'll park my lizard limousine and be right in."

Catra stepped out of Double Trouble's car - she refused to call it a lizard limousine, that was just stupid. Looking up at the building made her stomach churn, so Catra just looked at the front doors directly ahead of her. The entryway was far from the sketchiest she had ever seen, but the rehab center clearly did not have much funding. Catra gritted her teeth and pushed the front doors open.

"Catra? Holy shit, look who the cat dragged in!" said Bonnie.

"Bonnie? What the fuck are you doing working in this dump?" said Catra.

"After Rog came through here and got himself sorted out, I started looking at working in rehab. Lucky for me, this place is perpetually understaffed, so it's excellent job security. Better for my knuckles than bouncing at seedy bars the rest of my life."

"Holy shit," said Catra, "I did not expect you to be working in rehab."

"Yeah, well neither did I And nobody ever expected you actually going to rehab anytime this century," said Bonnie.

Double Trouble walked in through the front doors in their typical, over-the-top fashion - which is to say they threw the doors wide open and strutted in like they owned the place.

"Well Bonnie, I see you're catching up with the kitty-cat," said Double Trouble.

"No way , they got you to do this? What happened to Adora?" said Bonnie.

"Adora's - " Catra's voice broke and she had to take a deep breath - " she's gone, Bonnie, she disappeared on a mission five years ago. Nobody's heard from or seen her since. Officially, she's missing, presumed dead."

"Shit, Catra I'm so sorry ." Bonnie looked like she really meant it.

"It's fine, Bonnie, you didn't know . I never really stayed in touch after everything that happened," Catra said.

"Okay I've had enough of your icky feelings for the day , let's get Kitten here checked in and all set up for detox," said Double T rouble.

Bonnie set Catra up with what amounted to a glorified hospital room. A bed, bathroom and a tv comprised pretty much the whole room. The walls were a stark white, and the room reeked of bleach. It occurred to Catra that it might be a bad idea to have alcohol based substances in a facility where addicts would be going through detox It would only take one desperate idiot chugging hand sanitizer for things to go south.

Bonnie had returned to the front desk and Double T rouble had long since headed to work when the first withdrawal symptoms really started to hit. Catra's stomach began to churn rebelliously. She stood, stumbling towards the room's small bathroom. Inside the smell of bleach was even stronger, the previous resident must've really made one hell of a mess for it to be this bad.

Fortunately, Catra managed to make it to the toilet bowl before she was racked with convulsions, hurling into the bowl.

After several minutes, Catra wiped her mouth, "Ugh, Ifucking hate puking. Where's the fuckin' call-a-nurse button, Ireally don't want to clean this shit up."

Bonnie wasn't the one who answered the call, some other nurse - which made Catra wonder, what the hell were these people even called. But when she asked, the woman - who was so tall and

muscular she could've given Scorpia a run for her money - didn't respond.

Within the next hour, the sweats began. Cold, constant sweats ran down her back, preventing her from getting any sort of comfortable. When she tried to seek comfort under a blanket, Catra would overheat and have to throw it from her body. Within minutes, however, she would find herself shivering and shaking in her bed.

A few hours after the sweats had begun, something that Catra hadn't expected struck. She started hearing things, little snippets of a child's voice - it was so much like Finn's and yet it wasn't theirs. It almost reminded her of things too painful to recall. Sometimes she would hear something terse, like a snippet of news during a crisis. She saw things too, frightening flashes from her childhood and impossible figures.

Catra closed her eyes and attempted to force herself to sleep. If she slept she could escape the worst of the symptoms and ride it out in her dreams. This, of course, was a futile effort, and when Catra opened her eyes, frustrated, she found herself back in her childhood home.

"No no no, this can't be happening, this place burnt to the ground years ago, I can't be here," said Catra.

Logically, she knew that to be true, but every one of Catra's instincts was screaming at her to run, to go, to hide, to escape what she was

seeing. All the details of Weaver's Home for Troubled Foster Kids surrounded her, from the suspiciously dark reddish-brown stains in the floorboards to the exposed insulation and the popcorn ceiling.

Catra's inspection of her surroundings was interrupted by the ringing of the bell. The bell, the bell, oh goddess the bell. She had to run. She couldn't get caught. She couldn't get caught, the punishments would be unbearable.

As she started to run, Catra felt long and slender yet strong arms grab her around her torso and hold her tight. Catra fought to escape, she clawed and she bit, she scratched and she kicked. The arms holding her squirmed like tentacles.

And just like that Catra found herself back in the rehab center. It wasn't Shadow Weaver's arms that held her, but Bonnie's. Bonnie's arms were in bad shape. Catra had really done a number on her.

"What the hell just happened?"

"That's what I want to know, Kitten. You didn't react at all when we entered the room, and then all of a sudden you just tried to book it. When Bonnie grabbed you, you tried to claw the shit out of her," said Double Trouble.

"I-" Catra choked up, and had to take a deep breath before she could continue speaking -"I was back in the orphanage I grew up in

with Adora. t all seemed so real. t was like Iwas standing right there. And then Iheard the bell ring, the one she used to control us, and Ijust had to get out of there. t was like nothing else mattered."

"Shit, Cat, that sounds terrible. W e all heard stories of what went on in that place. Hallucinations are not uncommon with withdrawal, but that sounds worse than usual. t' s been twenty four hours so Ican release you to stay with DT for a week, while you recover some, but you can stay here for a few more days if you would like," Bonnie turned to Double Trouble. "About 1 in 20 people get what' s called Delirium Tremens, DT, if Catra gets tremors that progress beyond her hands, discombobulation, further hallucination, or profuse sweating, more than she's had so far, take her to the ER immediately. Delirium Tremens are pretty dangerous, and could really fuck her up,"

"I wanna go somewhere that doesnt smell like fucking bleach, honestly," said Catra. "Are you cool with that, DT?"

"I'll have you over anytime, Catra," said Double T rouble.

"Great, cool, Ithink Im going to nap now ," said Catra, just before the world winked out around her.

Catra woke up on a rainbow couch covered in a non-binary flag throw. Her head was throbbing and her mouth felt like someone had left multiple paper towels there.

"What happened, where am I?" she said. Her voice sounded thick, as if she were speaking through molasses.

"You're napping on my couch while you ride out your alcohol withdrawal, darling," said DT .

Catra groaned, "Ohh, I think I preferred it when you called me Kitten. Can we go back to that before I puke?"

Double Trouble smirked at her, "Nope, everyone who spends a night hungover on my gae couch is upgraded to darling, no takesy-backsies."

Catra looked down at the couch she was lying on. And then she looked back at it, again. On the second look, it hit Catra what the couch was.

"DT did you fucking buy the IKEA gay pride couch?" said Catra.

"Maybe," said Double T rouble.

"Fucking how? These things weren't even available to be bought!" she said.

"I have my ways," said Double T rouble.

"I fucking hate you, DT ," groaned Catra.

"Awww, I love you too, darling," said Double T rouble.

"I Hate you. Hate you with the fury of a thousand suns," mumbled Catra.

"Need some water , darling?" said Double T rouble as they approached with a glass of ice water.

"Oh fuck yes my head is fucking pounding, gimmie," said Catra.

"Gimmie, who?" said Double T rouble.

"Gimmie, Double T rouble?" said Catra hopefully .

"Eh, close enough. W ell work our way up to darling."They shrugged and handed her the glass of water over to her.

Catra chugged the glass of water. t felt like heavenly bliss.

"Oh holy shit Ineeded that. Thanks for that, darling,"Catra watched as Double Trouble tripped over themself at that.

"Oh, does the kitty have claws now?W ell see how that goes for her,"said Double T rouble.

Not long after Catra woke up and was fed, Double Trouble left their apartment to go to work. According to them, the kids needed their darling presence, whatever the hell that meant. Catra still wasnt certain what in the hell they did for a living. To pass the time between bouts of shakes, cravings, and gut-wrenching nausea, Catra turned on the mysteriously hot pink TVDouble T rouble had placed in front of the couch before leaving. Most of the channels in this area were kinda ass, but it was better than having nothing to distract her from the withdrawal.

When Double Trouble returned home, Catra had been feeling cold, so she had wrapped herself up in the non-binary flag throw.

"Feeling cold, darling?Y ou could always turn up the heater, you know,"said Double T rouble.

"This is more comfortable. Besides, what if I get too hot and then the whole apartment is too hot? That would suck. So I'm just wrapped up in the throw," Catra said.

Just as she said that, Catra shivered. She was still kinda cold, not having gotten up to search for more blankets because that would have cost her some of her precious heat.

"Well, darling, my car was scorching on the ride back, so I have plenty of heat to share, all you have to do is let me in."

Catra looked from her blanket pile to Double Trouble and back to the blanket pile and then back to Double Trouble.

"Fine," she said, opening the blanket pile, "but you had better be toasty."

"Oh I promise you I'm plenty hot, darling," said Double T rouble as they climbed in next to her .

They wrapped their body around hers, and Catra remembered just how long it had been since she had cuddled with someone other than Finn.

Catra’s heart skipped a beat as she realized she was starting to catch feelings for Double Trouble. She then felt it lurch as she processed that realization. They couldn't like her back, not after everything they said to her about her addiction. They were just doing this for Finn, Catra reminded herself, there’s no way they have any feelings back

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Catra woke up feeling like she had to puke. She pulled herself to the bathroom, her head pounding. As soon as her head was over the toilet bowl, Catra stopped fighting the need and let herself retch. She never actually produced any vomit, merely dry-heaving for a good ten minutes or so.

After she finished dry-heaving, Catra walked back to the couch. She was hungry, but she didn't want to eat just after dry heaving. Next to the couch was a note written in sparkly green ink.

“I left for work again, didn't want to wake you when you looked so peaceful. I left some breakfast in the microwave if you get hungry .”

Double Trouble, Catra realized, had signed the note by kissing it. Their green lipstick made an impressive mark on the paper. Catra chuckled at their theatrics, and set the note aside as she crawled back onto the couch. She wondered what schlocky romances the local channels would have up today.

As she reached for the remote, Catra realized she did not know what day it was. She pulled out her phone, but found that it was dead. Catra tried to recall what day the anniversary of Adora's death had fallen on, but she remembered so little of that week she had no idea what day it was. Eventually, Catra thought to flip to the news, where she found out it was 1:00 pm on Friday.

"Holy shit, it's Friday? I completely lost track of time," said Catra.

She sifted through the channels before settling on an animated remake of the classic romance, "Castaspella and Juliet." It wasn't that great, but it was something to pass the time. About three-quarters of the way through the movie, the front door to the apartment banged open.

"Honey, I'm home!" shouted Double Trouble.

"I'm not your honey!" replied Catra.

Double Trouble walked up behind the couch and draped their arms across her torso from above.

"You're not? You wound me, Catra," they said.

Catra just rolled her eyes. “So, you pining me for schlocky romance movies or what?”

“Oh Goddess, yes! I love schlocky romance movies. Wait, have you eaten anything yet?”

“No, I pretty much just woke up, and I was dry-heaving, so I don’t wanna eat yet,” said Catra.

“Okay , but think about it for me after the next movie, okay?” said Double Trouble.

“Fine, nom,” said Catra.

“Oh I’ll make you call me nommy alright,” said Double Trouble.

Catra’s heart skipped a beat.

“O-ohkay , let’s get to that movie, shall we?” said Catra.

“Of course, darling,” said Double Trouble.

Catra internally cursed whatever deity to cause her to fall hard for people who should under no circumstances reciprocate.

After about halfway through the movie, Catra's stomach started to feel settled enough that she felt it would be safe to try eating something. When she got up to go into the kitchen, she thought she heard something fall over, but when she turned around, nothing seemed to have fallen. She shrugged, and returned to the kitchen. h the microwave was a large baked potato.

Catra took it out of the microwave, sliced it into fourths, and set the microwave to high for four minutes. When it finished, she took it out, applied a liberal helping of shredded cheese and bacon from the fridge, and returned to the couch, baked potato in hand.

Catra ate it standing up, not wanting to get crumbs on the couch where she slept. After she returned her plate to the kitchen, Catra plopped down on the couch somewhat forcefully. t shouldnt have really done anything aside from maybe hurt her ass, but when Catra fell on the couch, her side of it collapsed underneath her.

"Shit!" she said.

"W ell fuck," said Double T rouble.

"Do you have any other chairs?" asked Catra.

“All I've got are bar stools, darling, and those are too high to watch the TV properly from. We can just watch from the floor though. I'll get my pillows and blankets!” said Double Trouble before immediately running to the bedroom, and returning with an armful of brightly colored blankets and pillows.

“Why are they so fucking bright?” said Catra.

“It's called fashion, darling, do try to keep up with it,” said Double Trouble.

The two of them built a comfortable nest of pillows to watch the rest of the day's romance selection, which eventually improved beyond schlock-tier into romance movies Catra could genuinely enjoy. By about nine pm, however, Catra was starting to feel very tired.

“Okay, how are we gonna do the sleep situation now?” she said.

“Hmm?” said Double Trouble groggily.

“Well the couch is kind of a bust, should I just go rent a hotel room?

"Unh uh, Catra, those things have alcohol in them. Also they're just generally unsanitary. We'll just share the bed!" said Double T rouble.

Catra tried to hide the blush that came to her cheeks at the thought of sharing a bed with Double Trouble.

"And you won't mind?" she asked.

"Oh no, of course not, darling. You're a guest in my house, and I am not sleeping on the floor. Not after last time," they said.

"Okay , if you're sure you're fine with it," said Catra.

"Of course I'm fine with it, I'm the one who suggested it after all," Double Trouble said.

Catra still felt like she was taking advantage of them somehow, but it was a far sight better than sleeping on the floor. The couch may not have been perfect, but at least it was cushioned.

Double Trouble led her into their bedroom, talking about their various play posters. Catra sat down on the bed, grappling with her feelings of guilt. If she hadn't been so useless, then they wouldn't have had to put up with her.

"Do you need anything, Catra? A glass of water? Some tea?" they asked.

"No, no I'm fine, just kinda tired," said Catra.

"Okay ," they said, sounding entirely unconvinced. "Do you want to be on the blankets or under them?"

"On them, please," said Catra.

Double Trouble got up to turn off the lights and then climbed into bed on the other side. Catra fought down the sense of disappointment at their separation. She closed her eyes and drifted off to sleep.

As she slept, Catra dreamt that she was fighting a massive snake, one that's head periodically shifted into people from her past. Adora, Bonnie, Entrapta, Shadow W eaver, even Double Trouble. Strangely, fighting the snake when it wore Double Trouble's head was almost as painful as when it wore Adora's head.

Catra snapped awake, and she began taking stock of the situation. It was dark still, so something must have woken her up. It took a moment for her to realize what it must have been.

Double Trouble was wrapped firmly around her in bed. She wriggled to no avail, she was firmly secured in their arms. Catra tried to ignore the fact that the person she probably totally had a crush on was holding her tight as they slept and just fall back asleep. She couldnt manage it for the life of her, and so she just lied there for what felt like an hour, still and unmoving, so as to not disturb Double Trouble.

Eventually, out of utter desperation, Catra snuggled back into them, and fell asleep within moments.

When Catra woke up she was purring lightly, snuggling up to Double Trouble.

"W ell, kitten, Im flattered, truly ," said Double T rouble.

"Oh fuck Im so sorry , Ididnt mean to intrude, I-" Catra fumbled out an apology before Double Trouble stopped her.

"Hush kitten, Iwanted it. Ilike you and Iknow you like me, so what' s stopping us? Im not going to be hurt by the fact that you want me," said Double Trouble.

They pulled her into a kiss and wrapped their arms around her. Catra hugged them back, and they fell back onto the bed. They did not get up for breakfast for some time.

While they were eating breakfast, Catra had to ask the awkward question, "So, are we dating now, or what?"

"Well, do you want to date me?" asked Double Trouble.

"Yeah kinda, but it just, it feels kind of disrespectful to Adora," said Catra.

"Kitten, what's disrespectful to Adora is drinking yourself into a stupor every night and denying yourself the chance to be happy. She would want you to be happy, Catra. You deserve to be happy," said Double Trouble.

"So, dating, uh yeah," said Catra.

Double Trouble leaned over and kissed her on the cheek. "I can work with that, kitten," they said.

Catra felt her stomach drop out as she realized she had forgotten about Finn.

"Oh sweet fuck, what are we going to tell Finn?" she said.

"Uh, that we're dating now and that I'll be around a lot more? What else are we going to tell them," they said.

"I don't know, I just thought maybe things would get kinda awkward with Finn" said Catra.

"Nonsense, darling, they love me, what is there to fear?" Double Trouble said.

Catra picked at her breakfast. She still wasn't certain about that. What if Finn didn't like her dating at all? What if it wasn't Double Trouble's fault, but her own?

"C'mere kitten, you look down, lemme hug you," they said.

Catra leaned into their embrace, and tried to let them comfort her. It worked more than she wanted to admit.

The week went by slowly, Catra was left fighting off cravings and shakes when Double Trouble was away, but when they returned each night, they hugged her tight and helped her through the worst of the symptoms. After Catra finally charged her phone, she saw that Perfuma had been sending her daily updates on Finn.

They were enjoying their time with Perfuma and Scorpia, but wanted to know when she would be coming back. Catra missed them too, but she wasn't ready yet.

Double Trouble eventually broached the subject one night over dinner.

"So, Kitten, when are you planning on getting back on your own two feet? It doesn't have to be now, I'd love to keep you all to myself for as long as I can, but Finn is going to want their mom back eventually, if they don't already," they said.

Catra dropped her utensils on her plate and held her head.

"I don't know, DT. I just don't know. I have to be a good mother for them, and I can't do that right now. I don't know if I ever can," she said.

"Catra, honey , you need to be honest with me and with yourself about the progress you've made. You've ridden the worst of the withdrawal without trying to seek out a fix. You've kept your motivation of being a better mother to Finn in mind constantly. You really are doing much better. This self-loathing isn't new is it, though?"

"No, it's not. Weaver really did a number on me. When Adora was here, it was manageable, but after she died things started to spiral and I hated myself for spiraling when Finn needed me. So I started drinking. The only day I didn't was the anniversary . It felt wrong, somehow. So I didn't, until after about five years I couldn't stand being sober that long. And that's about how you found me," she said.

Double Trouble wiped a tear from their eye. "I'm so proud of you, Kitten. This is the first you've really opened up to me about what plagues you in that cute little head of yours. I tell you what, how about when the last of the withdrawal symptoms subside, we go see Finn, explain to them about us, and if it goes well, we see about you getting back on your feet."

"Do you think that would be a good idea?" asked Catra.

"I do, Kitten, I really do," they said.

"Hey Auncle Dee?" said Finn.

"Y es dear?" said Double T rouble.

"Now that you and Mama are dating, what should I call you?" Finn said.

Catra's arms tightened around Double T rouble. Names were very important to Finn, and she wasn't certain if they had figured that out yet.

"Y ou can call me whatever you feel comfortable with, dear. Would calling me Nom make you more comfortable?" said Double T rouble.

Finn nodded.

"Then Nom it is. C'mere kitten," Double T rouble said, gesturing towards Finn.

They smiled, and leapt onto the couch with her and Double Trouble.

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t had been a few months into sobriety when everything went to shit. Double Trouble had practically moved in with Catra and Finn, since their apartment could actually fit all of them. Catra was still piecing herself together, and rebuilding the bridges she had burned through a steady combination of alcoholism and an already caustic personality.

She didnt get how Scorpia could have stood her for a fucking second, let alone put up with years of her shit. But somehow she stood by Catra nonetheless. They were even closer, now that she wasnt getting wasted every night, and they could interact.

t was Saturday when it happened. Double T rouble and Finn were playing upstairs while Catra was fixing lunch when from the front door came a knock.

"Coming!" said Catra.

She reached for the front door, and opened it, a little surly. Who the hell was coming by on a Saturday, Perfuma and Scorpia always had lunch together today - Catra processed who was on the other side of that door.

"Adora"?

"Hey , Catra," said Adora.

“What the hell is going on? Where the fuck have you been?” asked Catra.

“I was a POW . They took me but I never stopped fighting, not once. I knew I had to make it back, for you and Finn. It’s been a long, long five years, but I’m back, Cat.”

“I thought you were dead. How did you even survive?”

“Kitten, what’s wrong? Do you need me to come down and help you?” called Double Trouble.

Adora’s eyes widened.

“Look, Adora, I can explain, just please don’t get mad?” said Catra.

“I could never be mad with you Catra,” said Adora.

Inside, Catra felt the knife twist a little harder .

Double Trouble, Adora and Catra all stood around the dining table. Catra had taken Finn over to Scorpia and Perfuma's so they could all talk things out without scaring Finn if things got heated.

"I'm so sorry," she had said, "but could you please take them for the day? It's Adora."

She had said all she needed to, their faces were evident of that. They quickly ushered Finn inside, attempting to to distract them before they realized the emotional strife likely about to occur.

"So," said Adora. "What's happened since I was gone?"

"Well, they told me you were missing. After three months, it was changed to missing, presumed dead. They found your blood in the hummvee, Adora, lots of it. How could you have survived, they said. It was rough without you. Finn looked like such a perfect combination of both of us, their voice brought back memories every time they spoke," said Catra.

"Their?" asked Adora.

"Finn's nonbinary, they expressed it as soon as they could. You dont have a problem with that now, do you?" said Catra. She could feel her hackles rising in defense of Finn.

"No, no of course not, just a shock is all," said Adora.

"God," said Catra before continuing to fill in Adora on what had happened since her disappearance. Adora held her hand over her mouth as Catra detailed her spiral into severe alcoholism, but didn't say anything.

"A few months ago, DT came over to lecture me about my alcoholism, as I'd apparently pissed them off one too many times. They actually wanted to help me get better, if only so I'd do better by Finn. After a really rough rehab, we started dating, and they helped me put the pieces of my life back together," said Catra.

Adora rushed forward and hugged them both. "I'm glad you found someone who could fill the void I left behind."

"It's less that they filled the void, but filled a different need that I never knew I had. I still need you, Adora, I still miss you. Nothing could ever really fill that void," said Catra.

"Oh, um. I wasn't really expecting that, to be honest," said Adora.

"Look, Adora, honey, why don't we just all stay here while we figure this all out. Relationships are complicated things. We aren't going to

sort everything out in one sitting. Let's give it some time, and let things settle some," said Double Trouble.

Catra was lying in bed, head under a pillow when Finn came home.

"Mom, Nom, Mama, I'm home!" said Finn.

"Aww, Finn, you called me Mom," said Adora.

"Well, yeah, you're my mom. Just like Mama is my mama, and Nom is my nom," said Finn.

Catra knew Adora had to be full-on blubbering out there, even if she couldn't hear it. Finn's frankness with their feelings always made Adora emotional. Catra was about to get up and remind Adora it wasn't her fault she missed so much of Finn's life, but then she heard Double Trouble speaking.

"You are a good person, Princess, and don't you forget it. It's not your fault you were taken prisoner. You had no way of knowing that, okay? Catra, Finn and I don't blame you. You deserve to feel happy," said Double Trouble.

Catra had a brief moment to wonder if they knew why she called Adora "Princess" in intimate moments before a shriek pierced her protective pillow.

"Yay, Mom and Nom finally kissed! Auntie Scorpia owes me a hug," said Finn.

The front door slammed shut as they ran outside.

A few moments later, Adora and Double Trouble burst into the bedroom practically on top of each other.

"You horny assholes can do that elsewhere, I have a fucking headache!" said Catra.

"Oh. Sorry Catra," said Adora.

"Your loss, Kitten," said Double Trouble as they pulled Adora to the guest bedroom.

After clearly enjoying themselves, the pair collapsed back into Catra's bed, giggling.

I'm feeling just well enough to let you two cuddle, but not well enough to make you both make up for leaving me out earlier," said Catra.

I'm sorry Catra," said Adora, head buried in Catra's shoulders and arms wrapped around both her and Double Trouble.

It's fine, dummy ," said Catra, wrapping an arm around both of them. "I love you both so much."

End Notes

This was a bit more angsty than I usually go for , but I did write it. Not certain how much I can say I "enjoyed" writing it, because a lot of it was written while dealing with some unpleasant stuff irl. I did enjoy doing the fluffier stuff at the end though. Massive thanks to Z and another gal (who I haven't actually asked if I can mention by name) for giving this the ol' once-or-twice over . This took like two months to write so there were some unusual challenges from an editing standpoint, as well as just generally really helping me improve as a writer. I've already finished something for next week, but once again, anything beyond that is anyone's guess as to whether or not I have enough of a reprieve from college to write.

Thanks to everyone for reading, you lot really make my Fridays way better.

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